

Analyzing melodies

Looking closely at how melodies are constructed can help you understand their role and function. In a melodic analysis, always examine elements such as contour, repetition, rhythm, and scale degrees.

Contour

Take an overall look at the melody. What shape does it have—in terms of notes moving upward or downward, or ascending or descending? What is the overall range, from the lowest note to the highest note? Does the melody change the pitch direction frequently, or very little? Look for places where the melody is static with repeated notes, and for unexpected leaps or changes.

SEE ALSO

◀ 92–93 What is a tune?

◀ 96–97 Types of phrases

◀ 98–99 Sequences

Degrees of the scale 124–125 ▶

Repeats

154–155 ▶

Allegro

f Each line has an ascending pattern beginning on the note D, but ending only a 4th or 5th higher.

p Lines two and four cover a greater range of pitch within the first four notes, for a yearning sound. Each line has an identical rhythm, unifying the tune.

ff Frequently melodies contain a resting point halfway through, ending on *do* or keynote 1, the tonic.

mf **poco rit.**

mf A descending scale back to keynote 1 or *do* provides a cadence, closing the melody.

▽ “Down in the Valley”

Here the pitch range is only an octave. The only octave jump—from low D to high D—occurs near the end of the tune, the most dramatic placement.